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By Tommaso Lecca · Jul 28, 2026, 1:47 PM · [View in your browser](#)

BRUSSELS — Brussels South Charleroi Airport will suspend all flight operations in the second half of 2028 to allow a major reconstruction of its only runway and other infrastructure upgrades.

Belgium's second-busiest airport is expected to halt air traffic for 11 weeks, from Aug. 15 to Oct. 31.

"A complete refurbishment of Charleroi airport's sole runway (which has an estimated lifespan of 25 years), together with other major infrastructure modernisation works, has been scheduled by [airport infrastructure company] SOWAER for the second half of 2028," the airport said in an email.

"To minimise the overall duration of the disruption, the various construction projects will be carried out simultaneously," the airport added, noting that "this will require a temporary suspension of air traffic during the works."

The airport said it would work closely with all parties involved "to plan these projects, identify operational constraints and manage their impacts."

According to the latest figures from Belgian statistical office Statbel , 11.2 million passengers departed from or arrived at Charleroi airport in 2025, meaning an 11-week closure could affect more than 2 million passengers.

Belgian public broadcaster RTBF reported that the works will cost around €50 million.

"These investments are intended to ensure the airport's long-term safety, operational performance and attractiveness," the airport said.

Located about 70 kilometers south of Brussels, Charleroi airport is primarily served by Ryanair, followed by the Hungarian low-cost carrier Wizz Air and Turkey's Pegasus Airlines.

None of the three airlines immediately responded to requests for comment.

The closure is also causing concern among trade unions, which fear passenger traffic may not return to pre-closure levels once the airport reopens.

"We have been insisting with the airport management for at least two years to have a dialogue on the subject," said Alain Goelens, a representative of trade union SETCa, referring to the impact of the traffic suspension on employment.

He called for greater coordination between the airport and the Walloon regional government “to see how we are going to anticipate things, both for the staff and in relation to the airlines, to be sure that these companies will return.”

Cécile Neven, the Walloon minister responsible for airports, rejected accusations that the government had failed to plan.

“Contrary to what has been claimed, preparations for this project have been underway for many months,” her office said.

The runway closure is not the only issue raising concerns about the airport’s future. Passenger numbers have more than doubled since 2010, but Ryanair announced last week that it would remove five aircraft from its Charleroi base and cut 2 million seats from its Belgian network from next winter in response to an increase in the country’s boarding tax from €5 to €7.

The Belgian government’s original proposal was to raise the tax to €10, but it dropped the plan following pressure from the aviation industry.

Even so, the lower increase was not enough to convince Ryanair not to reduce capacity in Belgium.

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